

From Cybernetics to Presence: Consciounetic, Consciousnetics, and the Limits of Action-Based Theories of Consciousness

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Abstract

The scientific study of consciousness has proceeded largely by asking what conscious systems do: how they report, discriminate, integrate, and respond. This article argues that such action-based approaches systematically conflate three fundamentally distinct levels of description. *Cybernetics* concerns the instrumental regulation of systems through feedback, control, and information flow—powerful, productive, and indifferent to experience. *Consciousnetics* denotes the self-regulatory activity of agents operating *within* presence: attention, valuation, suffering, and learning as lived phenomena. The *Consciounetic* designates presence itself—singular, non-agentive, non-regulatory, and ontologically prior to both. We show that confusing these levels generates characteristic errors: the functionalist assumption that complexity produces presence, the panpsychist inflation that distributes consciousness without distinguishing singular presence from plural agents, and the eliminativist deflation that denies presence because it resists functional characterization. Through critical engagement with Global Neuronal Workspace theory, Integrated Information Theory, predictive processing, and higher-order approaches, we demonstrate that each framework operates at the cybernetic or consciousnetic level while remaining silent on the Consciounetic. The resulting reframing bridges rather than polarizes materialist and idealist traditions, clarifies the scope and limits of computational models, and motivates a non-action-based science of consciousness. Such a science would ask not what consciousness does, but what it means for experience to appear at all—directing inquiry toward low-action paradigms, contemplative methodologies, and phenomenological constraints capable of isolating presence from the regulatory activity that ordinarily accompanies it.

1 Introduction

The scientific study of consciousness has largely proceeded by asking what conscious systems do (Seth and Bayne, 2022; Wu, 2018). Subjects are presented with stimuli, tasks, or perturbations; their responses are measured, modeled, and interpreted as evidence of conscious experience. From behavioral reports to neural decoding, the dominant methodological assumption is that consciousness can be inferred from functional engagement with the world (Dehaene and Changeux, 2011; Baars, 1988).

This article argues that this assumption rests on an unexamined conflation. What is measured in such paradigms is not presence itself, but regulatory activity layered on top of presence. The challenge of understanding consciousness is of such magnitude

that, even with substantial progress being made, there remain robust discussions about appropriate definitions, conceptual foundations, and constraints on empirical research (Seth and Bayne, 2022; Chalmers, 2018). This difficulty may stem, in part, from the conflation we aim to disentangle.

The so-called “hard problem” of consciousness—why neurological activity gives rise to conscious experience at all, as opposed to nothing—remains a central challenge that some philosophers argue cannot be resolved through purely functional or neuroscientific explanation (Chalmers, 1995; Churchland, 1996). Indeed, some philosophers deny the hard problem altogether (Dennett, 2018), while others urge that we simply “learn the science, do the science, and see what happens” (Churchland, 1996). Perhaps the most common attitude for neuroscientists is to set the hard problem aside (Koch, 2004).

To make this distinction explicit, we introduce a three-tier framework distinguishing cybernetics, consciousnetics, and the Consciounetic. Philosophy of science can provide a systematic meta-theory that helps the research community converge around exactly what should be explained and how (Seth and Bayne, 2022; Van Gulick, 2018). The framework presented here is offered in this spirit.

2 Cybernetics: Instrumental Regulation

Cybernetics concerns the regulation of systems through feedback, control, and information flow (Wiener, 1948; Ashby, 1956). A cybernetic system receives inputs, transforms internal states, and produces outputs in order to maintain stability, optimize performance, or achieve predefined goals. The term itself, coined by Norbert Wiener from the Greek *kybernetes* (steersman), emphasizes the governance and control of systems regardless of their material substrate (Wiener, 1948).

Crucially, cybernetics is indifferent to experience. A thermostat, a neural network, and an economic model may all be cybernetic without there being anything it is like to be them (Nagel, 1974). Cybernetics describes how states are updated, not whether those updates are present to anything. This distinction echoes the “hard problem” of consciousness articulated by Chalmers: while we can model the functional and computational aspects of a system—perception, cognition, learning, and behaviour—the challenge remains to understand why and how any of this should be associated with consciousness at all (Chalmers, 1995). Why aren’t such systems simply robots, or philosophical “zombies,” without any inner experience? (Chalmers, 1996; Kirk, 2019).

Formally, cybernetics is plural: many systems, many controllers, many interfaces. It is inherently mechanistic and fully characterizable in functional terms (von Foerster, 2003; Bateson, 1972). This functional characterization is precisely what makes cybernetics so powerful for engineering and biological modeling, yet also what renders it silent on the question of presence.

The success of cybernetic explanation in neuroscience and artificial intelligence has reinforced the assumption that consciousness itself might yield to similar treatment (Seth and Bayne, 2022). However, as the hard problem literature makes clear, even a complete functional account—one that explains all the “easy problems” of access, reportability, and behavioral integration—may leave untouched the question of why there is subjective experience at all (Chalmers, 1995; Levine, 1983).

3 Consciousnetics: Self-Regulation in Presence

Consciousnetics denotes a distinct level of organization: the self-regulatory activity of an agent operating within presence. A consciousnetic agent does not merely regulate states; it regulates itself *as* experience.

This formulation draws on insights from the phenomenological tradition inaugurated by Edmund Husserl and developed by Martin Heidegger, Jean-Paul Sartre, and Maurice Merleau-Ponty (Smith, 2018; Merleau-Ponty, 2012). Phenomenology, as practiced by these thinkers, sought new ways of letting phenomena approach investigation “without covering them up with what they already knew” (Safranski, 2002). Central to this tradition is the recognition that consciousness is not a passive container of representations, but an active, intentional engagement with the world.

Merleau-Ponty’s work is particularly instructive here. In his *Phenomenology of Perception*, he affirms: “I am not in front of my body, I am in my body, or rather I am my body” (Merleau-Ponty, 2012). This insight—that the lived body is not an object among objects but the very subject of perception—resonates with the concept of consciousnetics as self-regulation from within experience rather than upon it (Gallagher, 2012). Merleau-Ponty’s phenomenology views the body as the “subject of perception,” a theme that has been taken up by contemporary enactive and embodied cognition frameworks (Varela et al., 1991; Noë, 2004).

Attention, valuation, intention, reflection, suffering, and learning belong to this level. Consciousnetics is normative rather than merely functional: states matter to the system precisely because they are lived (Thompson, 2007; Zahavi, 2005). The enactive approach to the mind-body relation, grounded in the notion of self-organization, has been shown to be consistent with Husserl and Merleau-Ponty on virtually every point (Thompson, 2007; Gallagher, 2017). This convergence supports the claim that consciousnetic regulation is not merely computational but inherently self-involving.

While consciousnetic agents employ cybernetic tools—neural mechanisms, predictive models, motor control loops—they are not reducible to them. Cybernetics provides the interfaces through which consciousnetics updates itself, but does not account for the presence in which those updates occur. As the enactive and embodied cognition frameworks emphasize, cognition arises through sensorimotor engagement with the environment; consciousness is not housed in the brain alone but emerges through dynamic interaction between organism and world (Varela et al., 1991; Thompson, 2007). Yet even this interactionist account, while capturing the *how* of consciousnetic regulation, does not by itself explain the *that* of presence.

Consciousnetics is plural. There are many consciousnetic agents, perspectives, and trajectories of self-regulation. Each agent is an embodied, historically situated locus of self-regulatory activity, what Sartre characterized as consciousness that is always consciousness *of* something, and always for-itself (Sartre, 1956; Zahavi, 2005). This plurality distinguishes consciousnetics from the Consciounetic, to which we now turn.

4 The Consciounetic: Presence Itself

The Consciounetic denotes presence as such. It is singular, non-agentive, and non-regulatory. It is not a system, not a subject, and not an instance among others. It does not act, compute, update, or respond.

This notion of presence—the sheer fact that experience appears at all—has been approached from multiple philosophical traditions, though it resists easy categorization. What we search for when we investigate consciousness is not merely the “appearances,” but rather what makes appearances be appearances in the first place—the “luminosity” of appearances, so to speak: presence as such (Fasching, 2008). But is this quality of being present something one can look at directly, something of which one can be specifically conscious? This question marks the boundary between consciousnetic reflection and the Consciounetic itself.

In Husserlian phenomenology, consciousness itself—in which all levels of transcendence come to givenness—does not “consist” of some immanent contents or data at all, but is nothing other than precisely consciousness of contents, pure intentionality (Zahavi, 1999). Husserl calls this “absolute consciousness,” the true and ultimate immanence that underlies all experience (Zahavi, 1999; Husserl, 1983). Husserl’s phenomenological reduction aims to define pure consciousness in its essential and absolute being by bracketing empirical data and suspending empirical subjectivity (Husserl, 1983). This absolute consciousness is not a thing among things but the condition for the givenness of any thing whatsoever.

Presence is not produced by regulation; regulation unfolds within presence. The Consciounetic is therefore ontologically prior to both cybernetics and consciousnetics, while depending on neither. As Jean-Luc Marion has argued, givenness is not a matter of some thing, being, or object given; rather, givenness is a mode of phenomenality, a question of the *how* or manner of phenomena (Marion, 2002). This insight aligns with the claim that the Consciounetic is not an entity but the very condition of appearing.

Non-dual philosophical traditions offer complementary perspectives. In the Advaita Vedanta of Adi Shankara, only Atman-Brahman is ultimately real; the individual *jīvātman* is ultimately non-different from Atman-Brahman, characterized as pure awareness, the witness-consciousness (Albahari, 2009). The Mahāvākyas documented in the Upanishads explain this unity and form the basis of the Advaita Vedanta tradition (Shankara, 1978). Similarly, certain Buddhist traditions point toward a non-dual basic experience of being alive—a presence that is simultaneously non-static and static, the sheer fact of experiencing prior to any particular content (, Rabjam).

Research on meditative states provides suggestive empirical correlates. Studies of “consciousness itself”—self-awareness isolated from the processes and objects of experience during practices such as Transcendental Meditation—report states characterized by the absence of the very framework (time, space, and body sense) and content (qualities of inner and outer perception) that define ordinary waking experiences (Travis and Pearson, 2000). Physiologically, such states are distinguished by apneustic breathing, autonomic orienting at the onset of breath changes, and increases in the frequency of peak EEG power (Travis and Pearson, 2000). These findings do not prove the existence of the Consciounetic as a metaphysical entity, but they suggest that presence can be experientially dissociated from consciousnetic regulation.

Importantly, the Consciounetic is not a metaphysical substance or hidden entity. It is simply the condition that there is something it is like for experience to occur at all (Nagel, 1974). To be self-aware, on one influential phenomenological account, is not to capture a pure self or self-object that exists separately from the stream of experience; rather, it is to be conscious of one’s experience in its intrinsic first-person mode of givenness (Zahavi, 1999). The Consciounetic names this givenness without reifying it.

Some have cautioned that concepts such as “pure consciousness” or “pure awareness” do

not by themselves account for the reflexivity of consciousness, the first-personal givenness, or the synchronic and diachronic unity of experience (Forman, 1990). This caution is well taken. The Consciounetic, as introduced here, is not intended as a full theory of subjectivity but as a minimal placeholder for what remains when all regulatory and agentive processes are conceptually set aside: the bare fact of presence.

5 Dependency Relations

Having introduced the three levels of our framework, we now make explicit their dependency relations. These relations are not merely terminological but carry ontological weight: they specify what can exist without what, and what presupposes what.

The relations between the three levels can be summarized as follows:

- **Cybernetics can exist without consciousnetics.** Feedback mechanisms, control loops, and information-processing systems operate in thermostats, ecosystems, and computational architectures without there being anything it is like to be such systems (Wiener, 1948; Ashby, 1956). Cybernetics, as a transdisciplinary study of circular causal processes such as feedback and recursion, is concerned with general principles relevant across multiple domains, independent of whether those domains include experiential beings (von Foerster, 2003). A system may exhibit sophisticated self-regulation—homeostasis, error correction, adaptive learning—while remaining entirely absent of presence.
- **Consciousnetics cannot operate without the Consciounetic.** Self-regulation *as* experience presupposes a field within which experience occurs. An agent that attends, values, suffers, or reflects does so only insofar as there is presence in which these activities unfold (Thompson, 2007; Zahavi, 2005). The consciousnetic agent is not the source of presence but its expression; it emerges within what is already given. As phenomenological analysis reveals, one might seek to explain how a given feature of consciousness is caused or realized by underlying processes, but the very givenness of any feature already presupposes the Consciounetic as its condition (Zahavi, 1999).
- **The Consciounetic depends on neither.** Presence itself is not generated by cybernetic processes, nor is it constituted by consciousnetic activity. It is ontologically prior to both. This priority is not temporal but structural: presence is the condition for the appearance of any process whatsoever, whether regulatory or self-regulatory (Husserl, 1983; Marion, 2002). The Consciounetic is not a higher-order fact presupposing lower-order facts; rather, it is that in virtue of which any fact can appear at all (Forman, 1990).

In short: *cybernetics updates systems; consciousnetics updates itself; the Consciounetic does not update—it is.*

5.1 Clarifying the Asymmetry

This asymmetry requires emphasis, as it is routinely obscured in the literature. Contemporary theories of consciousness often seek to explain how consciousness is caused or realized by underlying neural processes, biological structures, physical mechanisms,

or computational organization (Seth and Bayne, 2022; Dehaene and Changeux, 2011). Such explanations operate at the cybernetic and consciounetic levels: they model the mechanisms through which experiential content is shaped, integrated, and regulated.

But explaining mechanism is not explaining presence. A complete causal account of how neural processes generate the contents of experience would still leave unanswered the question of why there is experience at all rather than mere information processing (Chalmers, 1995; Levine, 1983). The Consciounetic marks precisely this remainder: not a gap in our knowledge, but a difference in kind between what can be functionally explained and what constitutes the condition of any explanation’s appearing.

Integrated Information Theory (IIT) represents an instructive case. IIT holds that experience is ontologically primary, and that integrated information formalism describes intrinsic phenomenology by quantifying the maximal irreducibility of causal distinctions, relations, and structures (Tononi et al., 2016). This is a significant advance insofar as it treats consciousness as fundamental rather than derivative. Yet IIT still characterizes consciousness in terms of system organization—causal structure, integration, exclusion (Oizumi et al., 2014). From the standpoint of the present framework, IIT provides a sophisticated account of the *structure* of consciounetic organization, but does not isolate presence as such. The exclusion postulate of IIT, for instance, states that each experience excludes all others and has definite borders (Tononi et al., 2016). This describes the formal properties of experiential content, not the bare fact that there is experiencing.

5.2 Against Conflation

The persistent conflation of these levels generates characteristic errors:

1. **The functionalist error:** Assuming that sufficient cybernetic complexity produces presence. No amount of feedback, recursion, or integration entails that there is something it is like to be the system (Block, 1995; Chalmers, 1996).
2. **The panpsychist inflation:** Distributing consciousness across all physical systems without distinguishing between the Consciounetic as singular presence and consciounetic agents as plural expressions (Goff, 2019; Albahari, 2009).
3. **The eliminativist deflation:** Denying presence because it cannot be functionally characterized, thereby eliminating the explanandum rather than explaining it (Dennett, 2018; Frankish, 2016).

The framework proposed here avoids these errors by maintaining clear distinctions. Cybernetics is real and explanatorily powerful within its domain. Consciounetics is real and captures the lived, normative dimension of self-regulating agents. The Consciounetic is real as the condition for both, though it is neither a system nor an agent nor a process.

5.3 Formal Summary

Let C_y denote the domain of cybernetic systems, C_n the domain of consciounetic agents, and C_o the Consciounetic. The dependency relations can be stated formally:

$$\begin{array}{ll}
\exists x \in C_y \wedge x \notin C_n & \text{(Cybernetics without consciousnetics)} \\
\forall x \in C_n \Rightarrow C_o & \text{(Consciousnetics presupposes the Consciounetic)} \\
C_o \not\Rightarrow \exists x \in C_y \wedge C_o \not\Rightarrow \exists x \in C_n & \text{(The Consciounetic is independent)}
\end{array}$$

These relations are not empirical hypotheses subject to falsification by neuroscientific data. They are conceptual constraints that structure how data should be interpreted. A neuroscientific finding that a certain brain state correlates with reported experience does not tell us whether that state *produces* presence or merely *modulates* consciousnetic content within a presence that is already given (Koch, 2004; Seth and Bayne, 2022).

6 A Critique of Functionalism

Functionalist theories of consciousness identify conscious states with functional roles, computational architectures, or causal relations (Putnam, 1967; Armstrong, 1968). On this view, what makes a mental state the state it is—a pain, a thought, a perception—is not its intrinsic character but its place within a network of inputs, outputs, and relations to other states. The early functionalist theories of Putnam can be seen as a response to the difficulties facing behaviorism as a scientific psychological theory, and as an endorsement of the new computational theories of mind which were becoming increasingly significant rivals to it (Putnam, 1967).

Within the present framework, functionalism succeeds only at the cybernetic and partial consciousnetic levels. It excels at characterizing the *structure* of mental organization: how information is processed, how states interact, how behavior is generated. What it cannot do is account for presence itself.

6.1 The Limits of Functional Explanation

No amount of functional complexity suffices to account for presence itself. A perfect functional duplicate may reproduce regulation without reproducing the Consciounetic. Functionalism thus explains behavior while remaining silent about being.

This limitation has been forcefully articulated through a series of thought experiments that have become central to the philosophy of mind. Philosophers have developed thought experiments that ask us to imagine situations beyond our ordinary experiences, and two of the best-known arguments against functionalism involve precisely this strategy (Block, 1978). These arguments do not merely point to gaps in current theory; they suggest a principled limitation on what functional explanation can achieve.

6.2 The Chinese Room

John Searle’s Chinese Room argument is aimed at computational versions of functionalism (Searle, 1980). Searle imagines himself locked in a room, manipulating Chinese symbols according to a rule book, producing outputs indistinguishable from those of a native Chinese speaker. Yet Searle understands nothing of Chinese; he merely shuffles symbols.

According to Searle, the functionalist theory leaves out and cannot account for the semantic properties of Chinese symbols, which are what a Chinese speaker actually understands (Searle, 1980). In a similar way, Searle argues, a computational system defined purely by its functional organization could never genuinely understand or be conscious, no matter how sophisticated its symbol manipulation.

Within our framework, Searle’s argument can be reformulated with greater precision. The Chinese Room is a cybernetic system: it receives inputs, transforms internal states according to rules, and produces appropriate outputs. It may even simulate certain consciousnetic functions—appearing to respond meaningfully, to “care” about the conversation. But there is no presence in the room. The symbol manipulation occurs, but it occurs for no one.

Critics have responded that Searle’s argument has limitations, and developments in contemporary artificial intelligence suggest that under certain circumstances machines may process information in ways that challenge his conclusions (Searle, 1980). Deep learning and natural language processing have advanced rapidly, prompting reconsideration of what machines might achieve. Yet even if a machine could process information with great sophistication, the question remains whether such processing is *present* to the system or merely functional. Searle’s experiment has had a lasting impact on discussions in philosophy and artificial intelligence, prompting continued reflection on the relationship between information processing and genuine understanding (Searle, 1980).

6.3 The China Brain

Ned Block’s China Brain (also known as the Chinese Nation) presents a different challenge (Block, 1978). Block imagines the entire population of China organized to simulate the functional organization of a human brain: each person plays the role of a neuron, communicating by radio. The system is functionally equivalent to a conscious human being.

Block’s Chinese Nation presents what has been called a qualia objection to functionalism because it purports to show that it is possible for something to be functionally equivalent to a human being and yet have no conscious experience (Block, 1978). Intuitively, there is nothing it is like to be the China Brain, even though it replicates every functional relation present in a conscious mind.

From the standpoint of the present framework, Block’s thought experiment illustrates the distinction between cybernetics and the Consciounetic with particular clarity. The China Brain is a cybernetic system of immense complexity. If we attribute consciousnetic properties to it—if we say that the system attends, values, or suffers—we do so only by analogy with genuine consciousnetic agents. But even granting such properties, the question of presence remains. Is there something it is like to be the billion-person network? The intuitive answer is no, and this intuition tracks the difference between functional organization and the Consciounetic.

6.4 The Hard Problem and the Explanatory Gap

David Chalmers has systematized these intuitions into what he calls the “hard problem” of consciousness (Chalmers, 1995, 1996). The easy problems concern the functional mechanisms of cognition: how we discriminate stimuli, integrate information, report mental states, access internal representations. These are “easy” not because they are simple, but

because they admit of functional explanation in principle. The hard problem, by contrast, concerns why any of this functional activity is accompanied by subjective experience at all.

The classic thought experiments from the likes of Block, Chalmers, and Jackson suggest that something crucial is missing from functionalism (Block, 1978; Chalmers, 1996; Jackson, 1982). If functionalism is to stand as a theory of consciousness, it must survive these philosophical challenges—not just from evidence, but from some of the most persistent and famous objections ever posed (Block, 1995).

Joseph Levine’s notion of the “explanatory gap” makes a related point (Levine, 1983). Even if we grant that conscious states are identical to functional or physical states, we lack any understanding of *why* those states should be conscious. The gap is not epistemic in a way that further neuroscience will close; it reflects a difference in kind between functional explanation and phenomenal presence.

Frank Jackson’s knowledge argument reinforces this conclusion (Jackson, 1982). Mary, the brilliant neuroscientist raised in a black-and-white room, knows everything functional and physical about color perception. Yet when she first sees red, she learns something new: what it is *like* to see red. This “something new” is precisely what functionalism cannot capture.

6.5 Functionalism’s Domain and Its Boundary

The foregoing critique should not be read as a rejection of functionalism altogether. Functionalism remains an indispensable framework for cognitive science, artificial intelligence, and much of neuroscience. It successfully characterizes the cybernetic and consciousnetic levels of organization: how systems process information, how agents regulate themselves, how behavior is generated and controlled.

What functionalism cannot do is cross the boundary into the Consciounetic. It can describe the architecture of experience but not the fact of experiencing. It can model the structure of self-regulation but not the presence within which self-regulation unfolds.

Putnam himself, who pioneered machine functionalism, later expressed doubts about its adequacy as a theory of mind (Putnam, 1967). The possibility that consciousness might be a fundamental property not reducible to functional organization has been taken seriously even by those sympathetic to computational approaches (Chalmers, 1996). Chalmers, for instance, has explored the possibility that consciousness is a fundamental property, which would leave functionalism explanatorily incomplete even if empirically useful (Chalmers, 1996).

The present framework clarifies this situation. Functionalism is not false; it is limited. It describes one level of reality—the cybernetic—with precision and power. It partially illuminates a second level—the consciousnetic—insofar as self-regulation can be functionally characterized. But it necessarily stops short of the third level—the Consciounetic—because presence is not a function. Presence is not what a system *does*; it is the condition under which any doing appears at all.

7 Relation to Contemporary Theories

With the distinctions introduced above firmly in place, it becomes possible to reassess several influential contemporary frameworks in the science of consciousness with greater

precision. The aim here is not to dismiss these theories, but to locate them correctly within the triadic structure of cybernetics, consciousnetics, and the Consciounetic.

A recurring source of confusion in the literature lies in the failure to distinguish between neural correlates of conscious access, reportability, or self-regulation, and neural correlates of presence itself. The former pertain to consciousnetic and cybernetic processes; the latter, if they exist, must correspond to the minimal conditions under which presence persists independently of task, stimulus, or action.

7.1 Global Neuronal Workspace Theory

Global Neuronal Workspace (GNW) theory characterizes consciousness as the global broadcasting of information across a distributed neural architecture (Baars, 1988; Dehaene and Naccache, 2001; Dehaene and Changeux, 2011). A mental state becomes conscious, on this view, when it gains access to a workspace that enables report, decision-making, and flexible control. The theory was first proposed by Baars as a cognitive architecture that identifies consciousness with the global availability of information; according to GNW, information becomes conscious when it is simultaneously made available to a wide network of processors (Baars, 1988, 2005).

The main postulate of GNW is that conscious access is global information availability: what we subjectively experience as conscious content corresponds to information that has been broadcast widely across the brain (Dehaene and Naccache, 2001; Dehaene and Changeux, 2011). Baars's original global workspace involves processors related to the past (memory), present (sensory input, attention), and future (value systems, motor plans, verbal report) (Baars, 1988). Thus, the global workspace achieves experiential integration that is, in terms drawn from the philosophy of mind, both synchronic (at a particular point in time) and diachronic (over time) (Baars, 1988; Seth and Bayne, 2022).

Empirical support for GNW comes from brain experiments showing that while unconscious visual stimuli evoke high activity in visual cortex, identical conscious stimuli reveal an additional spread of high brain activity to frontal and parietal lobes (Dehaene and Naccache, 2001; Dehaene and Changeux, 2011). Similar results have been found for hearing, touch, pain, and sensorimotor skills (Baars, 2005). The global neuronal workspace model predicts that conscious presence is a nonlinear function of stimulus salience; that is, a gradual increase in stimulus visibility should be accompanied by a sudden transition of the neuronal workspace into a corresponding activity pattern (Dehaene et al., 2006).

Within the present framework, GNW is best understood as a theory of conscious access rather than of presence. The workspace enables consciousnetic regulation: it allows an agent to integrate, evaluate, and act upon information in a coordinated manner. However, the existence of global broadcasting does not by itself explain why such broadcasting is present to experience at all.

GNW therefore provides a sophisticated account of how cybernetic and consciousnetic processes are orchestrated, but remains silent on the Consciounetic. Its empirical successes concern the availability of information for action, not the ontological fact of presence. The theory excels at explaining which contents become conscious (those that achieve global broadcast) and what cognitive functions consciousness enables (report, flexible control, integration). What it does not address is why global broadcast should be accompanied by presence rather than occurring, as it were, in the dark.

This is not a criticism of GNW as a scientific research program. It is a clarification of its explanatory scope. GNW operates at the interface of cybernetics and consciousnetics,

modeling how information flow is organized in systems capable of conscious access. The Consciounetic lies outside its domain.

7.2 Integrated Information Theory

Integrated Information Theory (IIT) proposes that consciousness corresponds to the intrinsic causal power of a system, quantified by measures of integrated information (Tononi, 2004; Tononi et al., 2016; Oizumi et al., 2014). Unlike GNW, IIT explicitly aims to capture consciousness as an intrinsic property rather than as a functional role. The theory begins from phenomenology—the essential properties of experience—and derives from these the properties that any physical system must have in order to be conscious (Tononi et al., 2016).

IIT identifies five essential properties of experience (the axioms) and translates them into corresponding properties of physical systems (the postulates): intrinsic existence, composition, information, integration, and exclusion (Tononi et al., 2016; Oizumi et al., 2014). The exclusion postulate states that each experience excludes all others and has definite borders; consciousness is always *this* experience rather than that one (Tononi et al., 2016). The central measure, Φ (phi), quantifies the amount of integrated information a system possesses above and beyond its parts.

Despite this ambition, IIT still characterizes consciousness at the level of system organization. Integrated information describes how a system constrains its own state transitions; it is therefore a theory of cybernetic self-coupling elevated to intrinsic status. High integration may be necessary for consciounetic agency, but it does not by itself account for the singularity of presence.

From the present standpoint, IIT risks conflating the richness of internal regulation with the existence of the Consciounetic. A system may exhibit strong intrinsic causal structure while remaining, in principle, absent of presence. IIT thus advances our understanding of self-organizing systems, but does not isolate presence as such.

To its credit, IIT takes seriously the idea that consciousness is fundamental rather than derivative. This aligns with the present framework’s treatment of the Consciounetic as ontologically prior. However, IIT locates fundamentality in the *structure* of integration, whereas the present framework locates it in presence itself, which is structureless. IIT provides a geometry of experience; it does not explain why there is experience at all.

7.3 Predictive Processing and the Free Energy Principle

Predictive processing frameworks portray the brain as a hierarchical inference engine minimizing prediction error or variational free energy (Friston, 2010; Clark, 2013; Hohwy, 2013). Perception, action, and learning are unified under the imperative to reduce surprise. The brain is conceived as a prediction machine that continuously generates models of the world and updates them in light of incoming sensory evidence.

This approach offers an elegant description of cybernetic regulation across multiple temporal scales. It explains how organisms maintain themselves within viable states by continuously updating internal models (Friston, 2010; Seth, 2014). The free energy principle provides a unifying framework under which perception, action, attention, and learning can all be understood as forms of prediction error minimization.

When extended to conscious experience, however, predictive processing typically equates consciousness with the contents or dynamics of these models (Seth, 2014; Hohwy, 2013).

Conscious perception is said to be the brain’s “best guess” about the causes of sensory input; emotions are interoceptive predictions; selfhood is a predictive model of the organism.

Within the present framework, predictive processing describes the machinery through which consciousnetics operates, not presence itself. Error minimization governs how experience is shaped, structured, and updated, but does not explain why these processes are present rather than merely functional.

Consider: a sophisticated predictive processing system could, in principle, minimize prediction error, maintain homeostasis, and generate adaptive behavior without there being anything it is like to be that system. The mathematics of variational inference is indifferent to presence. The system updates its models, but the updates need not appear to anyone.

Predictive processing thus provides a powerful account of the *form* of experience—why perception has the structure it has, why attention is allocated as it is, why certain contents reach awareness while others do not. What it does not provide is an account of the *fact* of experience: that there is appearing at all.

Some proponents of predictive processing have acknowledged this limitation and sought to address it by combining the framework with other approaches, such as IIT (Seth, 2014). These hybrid accounts are promising but face the same fundamental challenge: no matter how sophisticated the model of experiential *structure*, the question of experiential *presence* remains.

7.4 Higher-Order Theories

Higher-order theories (HOT) propose that a mental state is conscious when it is the object of a higher-order representation—typically a thought or perception about the first-order state (Rosenthal, 2005; Lau and Rosenthal, 2011). On this view, what distinguishes conscious from unconscious mental states is not their intrinsic character but the presence of a meta-representational layer.

HOT approaches have empirical traction: they predict specific neural signatures associated with meta-cognitive processes, and they align with findings on the role of prefrontal cortex in conscious report (Lau and Rosenthal, 2011; Dehaene and Changeux, 2011). They also offer a natural explanation for phenomena such as introspective error and the dissociation between perception and awareness.

Within the present framework, higher-order theories operate squarely at the consciousnetic level. They describe a form of self-regulation in which an agent monitors and represents its own states. This meta-cognitive activity is a hallmark of consciousnetic organization: the agent does not merely process information but takes its own processing as an object of further processing.

However, HOT faces a regress problem that illuminates its limitations. If a first-order state requires a higher-order state to be conscious, what makes the higher-order state conscious? Either we posit an infinite regress of ever-higher orders, or we accept that at some level, a state is conscious without being represented by a further state (Rosenthal, 2005; Kriegel, 2009).

From the standpoint of the present framework, this regress points toward the Consciousnetic. At some point, the chain of representations must terminate in presence itself—not another representation, but the condition under which any representation can appear. HOT describes the architecture of self-monitoring but cannot explain the presence in

which monitoring occurs.

7.5 Neural Correlates of Consciousness Revisited

Much of contemporary neuroscience seeks to identify neural correlates of consciousness (NCCs). The NCC is typically defined as the minimal neural mechanisms jointly sufficient for any one specific conscious experience (Koch, 2004; Crick and Koch, 2003). Research programs have sought NCCs for visual awareness, auditory perception, pain, and other modalities.

The neural correlates of consciousness are typically sought by comparing the overall brain responses to perceived and unperceived stimuli (Dehaene and Changeux, 2011; Rees et al., 2002). This contrastive method has yielded important findings: the role of recurrent processing, the involvement of frontoparietal networks, the signatures of ignition in the global workspace (Dehaene and Changeux, 2011; Lamme, 2006).

Yet without a clear distinction between presence and regulation, NCC research risks systematic ambiguity. Correlates of reportability, attention, or working memory may be misidentified as correlates of consciousness per se (Aru et al., 2012; Koch et al., 2016). Recent research on the relationship between consciousness and working memory, for instance, suggests that working memory is closely associated with conscious experience, though not identical to it (Baars, 2005).

The framework proposed here suggests a refinement: distinguishing NCCs of conscious access from NCCs of presence. The former correspond to consciousnetic regulation—the neural processes that enable report, integration, and flexible control. The latter, if discoverable, would correspond to neural and bodily conditions under which presence persists even when access, report, and task engagement are suspended.

This shift reframes the empirical challenge. Rather than asking which neural patterns accompany conscious performance, the question becomes which patterns remain invariant when performance dissolves but presence remains. Paradigms involving minimal awareness states, dreamless sleep with preserved minimal phenomenology, or deep meditative absorption may prove particularly informative (Thompson, 2015; Windt, 2015).

Research on the neural correlates of consciousness has also investigated the role of thalamocortical loops. Stimulation of central lateral thalamus, for instance, has been shown to counter anesthesia and restore wake cortical dynamics and consciousness, suggesting that the NCC involve both corticocortical feedforward and feedback pathways coordinated with intracolumnar and thalamocortical loops (Redinbaugh et al., 2020). Such findings illuminate the neural machinery of conscious access but do not yet isolate the correlates of presence as such.

A closely related line of inquiry concerns the study of qualia: the felt qualities of experience, often framed as what it is like to see red, feel pain, or experience joy (Nagel, 1974; Jackson, 1982). In contemporary neuroscience, the search for neural correlates of consciousness is frequently paired with attempts to localize or characterize these qualitative contents.

Within the present framework, such investigations must be situated carefully. The study of qualia, as it is typically conducted, concerns the structured contents of experience rather than the condition of presence itself. Sensory qualities, affective tones, and cognitive textures are all manifestations of consciousnetic regulation operating through cybernetic substrates. They describe how experience is shaped, modulated, and differentiated, not how experience is possible at all.

In this sense, the scientific investigation of qualia belongs primarily to cybernetics and consciousnetics. Neural patterns correlated with particular qualitative states reveal how biological systems generate and regulate experiential content. They do not, however, isolate the Consciounetic as presence. A complete mapping of qualitative variations would still leave unanswered the question of why these variations are present rather than merely functional.

This reframing does not diminish the importance of qualia research. On the contrary, it clarifies its scope. Studies of qualitative content advance our understanding of the internal organization of experience, its dimensions, and its lawful transformations. What they do not yet address is the deeper question of the minimal conditions under which any quality can appear at all.

Recognizing this distinction helps prevent a common slide in the literature, whereby increasingly detailed accounts of experiential content are taken to approximate an explanation of presence. The two enterprises are complementary but non-identical: one maps the space of experience, the other seeks to understand the ground upon which that space appears.

8 Toward a Non-Action-Based Science of Consciousness

A science of consciousness that takes the Consciounetic seriously would not ask primarily what systems do, but what it means for experience to appear at all. Its methods would emphasize phenomenological invariants, suspension of task demands, and the systematic quieting of self-regulatory loops.

8.1 The Limits of Action-Based Paradigms

Contemporary neuroscience of consciousness relies overwhelmingly on action-based paradigms. Subjects are presented with stimuli; they report, discriminate, or respond; neural activity is correlated with these behaviors. With advances in brain research, the presence or absence of experienced phenomena underlies the work of neuroscientists who seek to analyze the precise relation of conscious phenomenology to its associated information processing in the brain (Seth and Bayne, 2022; Dehaene and Changeux, 2011).

Yet these paradigms are structurally limited. They can identify the neural correlates of conscious *access*—the processes that enable report, discrimination, and flexible control—but they cannot isolate the correlates of *presence* as such. The methodological challenge in testing for the presence of phenomenal consciousness independently of access remains a hurdle for existing theories (Block, 1995; Lamme, 2006).

This limitation is not merely technical; it is principled. Action-based paradigms presuppose that consciousness is manifest in what systems do. But if the Consciounetic is prior to action, then no amount of behavioral or neural correlation with action will capture it. We would be measuring the ripples while ignoring the water.

8.2 Phenomenological Constraints

Phenomenology offers an alternative methodological orientation. Rather than asking what conscious systems do, phenomenology asks what experience *is* in its essential struc-

ture. This is an argument based on first-person observation, which goes back at least to Moore’s recognition that when one turns attention away from, say, the blue sky and onto one’s experience itself, one is still only aware of the blueness of the sky (Moore, 1903; Zahavi, 2005). The transparency of experience to its objects poses a methodological challenge: how can we study presence without turning it into another object?

Phenomenology can be productively integrated with cognitive science when we work with a de-transcendentalized “phenomenological psychology” and use its analyses of mental states and processes to constrain multi-level mechanistic explanations (Gallagher, 2012; Varela, 1996). This neurophenomenological approach treats first-person reports not as mere behavioral outputs but as data that constrain and guide third-person investigation.

For a science oriented toward the Consciounetic, phenomenological constraints become central. The aim is not to explain away first-person experience but to hold it steady as an invariant while investigating what conditions its appearance. By foregrounding intentionality, embodiment, temporality, and presence, such an approach challenges reductionist paradigms while offering rigorous methodology (Thompson, 2007; Petitot et al., 1999).

8.3 Contemplative Methodologies

Meditative practices may be understood, within this framework, as experiments that progressively suspend consciousnetic regulation while leaving presence intact. Such practices do not eliminate cybernetics, but decouple agency from its instrumental imperatives.

Consider the practice of objectless awareness cultivated in various contemplative traditions. The practitioner systematically withdraws attention from perceptual objects, thoughts, and self-referential processes, aiming to rest in awareness itself (Lutz et al., 2008; Dunne, 2011). What remains, according to experienced practitioners, is not blankness but presence without content—the sheer fact of experiencing prior to any particular experience.

This phenomenology is significant. If presence can be experientially dissociated from consciousnetic activity, then presence is not identical to such activity. The contemplative traditions thus provide existence proofs: demonstrations that the Consciounetic can be disclosed when regulation is suspended (Thompson, 2015; Forman, 1990).

Of course, contemplative reports are not self-validating. They require interpretation, triangulation with third-person measures, and careful attention to the shaping effects of tradition and expectation (Lutz et al., 2008). But they offer a methodological resource largely untapped by mainstream consciousness science: systematic protocols for attenuating consciousnetic activity while preserving presence.

8.4 Low-Action Paradigms

A non-action-based science of consciousness would develop experimental paradigms that minimize task demands, behavioral requirements, and stimulus-driven processing. The aim would be to isolate the neural and physiological conditions under which presence persists when access, report, and task engagement are suspended.

Several existing paradigms gesture in this direction:

- **Resting-state neuroimaging:** Studies of spontaneous neural activity in the absence of explicit tasks have revealed organized patterns of brain dynamics, including

the default mode network (Raichle et al., 2001). While typically interpreted in terms of self-referential cognition, resting-state paradigms could be adapted to investigate the neural correlates of minimal presence.

- **Sleep and dream research:** Dreaming presents a natural dissociation between presence and environmental coupling. The dreamer is present without acting in the world, revealing that presence does not require sensorimotor engagement (Windt, 2015; Thompson, 2015). Lucid dreaming, in which metacognitive awareness emerges within the dream state, offers an even more refined paradigm.
- **Anesthesia and minimal consciousness:** Studies of the transition into and out of anesthesia, as well as conditions such as the minimally conscious state, probe the boundaries of presence (Koch et al., 2016; Redinbaugh et al., 2020). Stimulation of central lateral thalamus, for instance, has been shown to restore cortical dynamics and consciousness during anesthesia, suggesting neural conditions necessary for presence.
- **Sensory deprivation:** Flotation tanks and controlled sensory reduction minimize cybernetic throughput while preserving presence. These conditions are often associated with unusual phenomenology—altered time perception, dissolution of body boundaries, enhanced introspective clarity—that may illuminate the structure of minimal presence (Feinstein et al., 2018).
- **Meditation research:** Neuroimaging and electrophysiological studies of advanced meditators during objectless awareness practices provide data on neural correlates of presence with minimal content (Lutz et al., 2008; Travis and Pearson, 2000). These studies suggest that presence can be maintained while the usual markers of cognitive activity are attenuated.

8.5 Toward a Descriptive Science of Presence

The foregoing considerations point toward a descriptive science of presence rather than an interventionist science of behavior. Such a science would not manipulate stimuli and measure responses; it would cultivate conditions under which presence is maximally disclosed and minimally obscured by regulatory activity.

Its questions would differ from those of mainstream consciousness science:

- What are the minimal neural and physiological conditions under which presence persists?
- Can presence be experimentally dissociated from access, report, and self-regulation?
- What phenomenological invariants characterize presence across different states and conditions?
- How do contemplative practices systematically attenuate consciousness activity while preserving presence?

New research argues that developing scientific tests for awareness could transform medicine, animal welfare, law, and artificial intelligence development (Seth and Bayne, 2022; Koch et al., 2016). But identifying consciousness in machines, brain organoids, or

patients requires clarity about what we are testing for. The present framework suggests that tests for *access* are not equivalent to tests for *presence*. A system might pass all access-based tests while lacking presence, or possess presence while failing access-based tests.

This reframing does not solve the methodological challenges; it clarifies them. A non-action-based science of consciousness would require new experimental designs, new interpretive frameworks, and sustained dialogue between neuroscience, phenomenology, and contemplative traditions. But it would be aimed at the right target: not what consciousness does, but that it is.

Experience is nonphysical in a specific sense: one cannot physically touch it and register a reaction force, or objectively measure its mass, size, or temperature (Nagel, 1974; Chalmers, 1996). One can measure the substrate—neurons, synapses, electrochemical signals—but the experientialness itself, presence as such, is without the kind of physical presence that admits of direct measurement. This is not mysterianism; it is a recognition that presence may require methodologies calibrated to its unique character.

8.6 The Place of Phenomenology in Consciousness Science

A non-action-based science does not abandon third-person methodology; it integrates first-person phenomenology as a co-equal partner. The neurophenomenological research program initiated by Varela proposes exactly this: a circulation between phenomenological description and neuroscientific investigation, in which each informs and constrains the other (Varela, 1996; Lutz and Thompson, 2003).

Within this program, first-person data are not reduced to behavioral reports but are treated as structured descriptions of experiential invariants. The challenge is to develop rigorous methods for generating such descriptions—methods that can be taught, replicated, and refined (Petitmengin, 2006).

For the study of the Consciounetic specifically, phenomenological methods would aim to describe presence in its minimal form: what remains when perceptual content, cognitive activity, and self-referential processes are systematically attenuated. Contemplative traditions have developed sophisticated vocabularies for such descriptions, and these vocabularies can be adapted for scientific purposes (Dunne, 2011; Lutz et al., 2015).

The result would be a science that takes seriously both the explanatory power of neuroscience and the irreducibility of first-person presence. It would not explain presence away but would seek to understand the conditions under which presence appears, persists, and is structured in the ways phenomenology reveals.

9 Implications for Theories of Consciousness

The reframing proposed in this article has consequences that cut across traditional metaphysical divides in the study of consciousness. By separating cybernetics, consciounetics, and the Consciounetic, we obtain a conceptual scaffold capable of accommodating insights from both materialist and idealist traditions without collapsing one into the other. Rather than forcing a choice between consciousness as derivative or fundamental, the framework clarifies what each school is in fact addressing.

In philosophy and metaphysics, materialism holds that matter is the fundamental substance of nature, so that all things, including mind and consciousness, arise from material interactions and depend on physical processes (Stoljar, 2021). Idealism, by

contrast, holds that mind or consciousness is fundamental, and that what we call matter is derivative or dependent upon it (Guyer and Horstmann, 2015). The traditional contrast between these positions has shaped debates in philosophy of mind for centuries, yet both camps have struggled to account for the full dimensionality of conscious experience (Chalmers, 1996).

The framework developed here suggests that materialists and idealists may be addressing different levels of the triadic structure. Materialists excel at characterizing cybernetic and consciousnetic processes—the mechanisms through which experience is shaped, regulated, and instantiated in biological systems. Idealists, meanwhile, gesture toward the Consciounetic—the condition of presence that is presupposed by any such mechanism. The apparent conflict dissolves when we recognize that mechanism and presence operate at distinct ontological levels.

This section explores how the distinction reshapes research programs within these two broad families of thought.

9.1 Implications for Materialist Approaches

Within materialist and physicalist frameworks, consciousness is typically approached through its functional and neural correlates. Experimental paradigms emphasize task performance, stimulus-response mappings, and reportability as proxies for conscious experience (Dehaene and Changeux, 2011; Koch, 2004). While productive, this focus systematically entangles conscious presence with consciousnetic regulation.

The introduction of the Consciounetic allows for a sharper question: what are the minimal neural and bodily conditions under which presence itself persists, independent of task, action, or external engagement? Rather than asking how brains support cognition, this reframing asks how biological systems sustain presence when cybernetic and consciousnetic demands are attenuated.

Several empirical domains become especially salient in this light:

- **Dreaming and lucid dreaming:** Dreaming offers a natural laboratory in which presence persists despite the near-total absence of sensory input and overt behavior. The dreamer is present without acting in the world, revealing a dissociation between presence and environmental coupling (Windt, 2015; Thompson, 2015). Studying neural dynamics during such states may therefore illuminate the minimal correlates of the Consciounetic rather than those of task-driven cognition. Lucid dreaming, in which metacognitive awareness emerges within the dream state, provides an even more refined paradigm for investigating presence with minimal external engagement.
- **Sensory reduction methodologies:** Methodologies that drastically reduce sensory and motor engagement—such as flotation tanks, controlled sensory deprivation, or extended stillness practices—may prove uniquely informative (Feinstein et al., 2018). These approaches are often marginalized because they appear unproductive from a performance-based standpoint. Yet precisely because they suspend cybernetic throughput, they may expose the neural and physiological invariants of presence.
- **Anesthesia and disorders of consciousness:** The transitions into and out of anesthesia, as well as conditions such as the vegetative and minimally conscious

states, probe the boundaries of presence (Koch et al., 2016; Redinbaugh et al., 2020). These clinical and experimental contexts allow investigation of the conditions under which presence is lost and recovered.

- **Meditative absorption:** Advanced meditative states characterized by minimal content but preserved presence offer another window (Travis and Pearson, 2000; Lutz et al., 2008). Neural and physiological correlates of such states may reveal what sustains presence when cognitive and perceptual activity is attenuated.

From this perspective, a non-action-based neuroscience of consciousness does not reject material explanation. Instead, it refines its target: not the mechanisms of regulation, but the conditions under which regulation can fall silent while presence remains. Materialism need not be abandoned; it must be extended to address a phenomenon—presence—that its standard methods have not yet isolated.

9.2 Implications for Idealist and Panpsychist Approaches

Idealist and panpsychist traditions invert the explanatory priority of materialism, treating consciousness as fundamental rather than derivative (Goff, 2019; Kastrup, 2019). Some idealists point out that materialism is being challenged by developments in science itself, particularly in quantum physics, which implies that there is no observer-independent world (Kastrup, 2019; Hoffman, 2019). This resonates with perspectives long held in Eastern philosophy, where consciousness is often regarded as primary.

Thinkers ranging from Berkeley to contemporary panpsychists, and physicists such as John Archibald Wheeler with his participatory universe, have suggested that observation or experience plays a constitutive role in reality itself (Wheeler, 1990; Stapp, 2011). For Wheeler, information was not merely descriptive of reality but constitutive of it. He described the universe as a “participatory universe,” in which observers are not passive witnesses but active agents in bringing tangible reality into being (Wheeler, 1990). His delayed-choice experiments demonstrated that present observations can retroactively determine the past behavior of quantum systems—findings that some interpret as consistent with idealist views where time and separateness are derivative rather than fundamental (Stapp, 2011; Wheeler, 1983).

Wheeler’s famous “it from bit” doctrine proposed that information is the most fundamental building block of reality, and that the universe should be seen as a self-synthesized information system (Wheeler, 1990). His iconic diagram of an eye observing the Big Bang suggests that conscious observation participates in the very constitution of the cosmos. Throughout the 20th century, leading physicists explored the idea that observation plays a fundamental role in shaping physical reality, reinforcing the notion that consciousness actively participates in the unfolding cosmos (Stapp, 2011).

The concept of the Consciounetic resonates naturally with these views, while also sharpening them. If presence is singular and non-pluralizable, it may be understood as the primary field from which all consciounetic agents emerge. Individual minds are not separate instantiations of consciousness, but differentiated modes of self-regulation occurring within a shared Consciounetic presence.¹

¹A speculative but structurally coherent implication of this view concerns phenomena traditionally described as synchronicities (Jung, 1960): meaningful correlations lacking apparent causal mediation. Within the present framework, such correlations need not be understood as violations of physical causal-

In this sense, the framework offers a disciplined articulation of unity without erasing plurality. The many consciousnetic agents are real, embodied, and historically situated, yet their being-present is not private or additive. This echoes Wheeler’s insight that observers are not external spectators of the universe, but participatory expressions within a deeper structure of appearing (Wheeler, 1990).

Panpsychist views that attribute proto-consciousness to all matter may also be reinterpreted here (Goff, 2019; Strawson, 2006). Rather than distributing consciousness across entities, the Consciounetic reframes consciousness as that in which entities appear at all. What is fundamental is not that everything is conscious, but that presence precedes and grounds all manifestation.

This move avoids both naive anthropomorphism and vague metaphysical inflation. It locates unity at the level of presence, not at the level of subjects or systems. Panpsychism, on this reading, correctly intuits that consciousness is fundamental but errs in distributing it across entities rather than recognizing it as the singular condition for the appearance of any entity.

9.3 Bridging the Divide

The traditional contrast between materialism and idealism has often led to a systematic disregard of intermediate positions and phenomena that fit neither category neatly (Nagel, 1974; Chalmers, 1996). The framework proposed here offers a bridge.

For materialists, the Consciounetic is not a competing substance or a mysterious addition to the physical world. It is simply the condition under which physical processes can appear at all. A materialist science of consciousness can proceed as before, investigating neural mechanisms and functional architectures, while recognizing that presence itself is not one more mechanism to be discovered but the condition for any discovery.

For idealists, the Consciounetic provides a precise articulation of what is meant by the primacy of consciousness. It is not that minds create matter, or that reality is “merely” mental. Rather, presence is the ontological ground within which both mental and physical descriptions find their place. The Consciounetic is not mind in the sense of a thinking subject; it is the prior condition for any subject-object distinction.

For panpsychists, the framework suggests a shift from distributing consciousness across entities to recognizing consciousness as the singular field within which entities are distinguished. This avoids the combination problem—how micro-conscious entities combine into macro-conscious subjects—by denying that consciousness is fundamentally plural at all.

The result is not a grand synthesis that resolves all metaphysical disputes, but a clarification of what is at stake in each position. Materialists, idealists, and panpsychists are addressing different aspects of the triadic structure: cybernetics and consciousnetics on the one hand, the Consciounetic on the other. Recognizing this can transform adversarial debate into complementary investigation.

ity, but as relations intelligible at the level of presence rather than at the level of cybernetic regulation. If the Consciounetic is singular and non-plural, then what appear as separate consciousnetic agents are in fact expressions of a single presence. Correlations between their experiences might then reflect this underlying unity rather than causal interaction. This observation does not constitute empirical proof of the Consciounetic, but suggests a possible phenomenological signature of ontological unity when causal explanation is misapplied across levels.

10 Conclusion

This article has argued that much of the contemporary difficulty in the study of consciousness arises not from a lack of data or theoretical ingenuity, but from a persistent conflation of distinct explanatory levels. By introducing and rigorously separating cybernetics, consciousnetics, and the Consciounetic, we have proposed a reframing that clarifies both the ontology of presence and the epistemology of its study.

10.1 Ontological Clarification

At the ontological level, the distinction makes explicit that presence itself is not a system, a process, or an instance among others. The Consciounetic is singular, non-agentive, and non-regulatory: it does not act, compute, or update. It is not a substance, not a subject, and not an entity that could be pluralized or counted. It is simply the condition that there is something it is like for experience to occur at all (Nagel, 1974; Chalmers, 1995).

Consciousnetics, by contrast, concerns the self-regulatory activity of agents operating within presence. A consciousnetic agent attends, values, intends, suffers, and learns—it regulates itself *as* experience (Thompson, 2007; Zahavi, 2005). This level is plural: there are many consciousnetic agents, each embodied and historically situated, each tracing a distinctive trajectory of self-regulation.

Cybernetics concerns the instrumental mechanisms and interfaces through which regulation is implemented (Wiener, 1948; Ashby, 1956). Feedback loops, control systems, and information-processing architectures operate at this level, indifferent to whether their operations are present to anyone.

Confusing these levels leads to the systematic error of mistaking regulation for presence. The hard problem of consciousness—explaining why any physical state is conscious rather than nonconscious, why there is “something it is like” for a subject in conscious experience (Chalmers, 1995)—persists in part because the question is posed at the wrong level. Functional and neural explanations operate at the cybernetic and consciousnetic levels; presence belongs to the Consciounetic, which is not itself a further mechanism to be explained but the condition for the appearance of any mechanism.

10.2 Epistemological Reorientation

At the epistemological level, the framework explains why action-based, task-driven methodologies have been so productive and yet so limited. Such methods are exquisitely sensitive to cybernetic and consciousnetic dynamics—access, reportability, control, and learning—while remaining structurally blind to presence itself (Dehaene and Changeux, 2011; Seth and Bayne, 2022).

Recognizing this blindness does not invalidate existing research; it situates it. Global Neuronal Workspace theory illuminates the mechanisms of conscious access (Baars, 1988; Dehaene and Naccache, 2001). Integrated Information Theory characterizes the intrinsic causal structure of systems capable of experience (Tononi et al., 2016; Oizumi et al., 2014). Predictive processing describes the hierarchical inference through which experience is shaped and updated (Friston, 2010; Clark, 2013). Higher-order theories model the meta-cognitive architecture of self-monitoring agents (Rosenthal, 2005; Lau and Rosenthal, 2011). Each of these frameworks makes genuine contributions to our understanding of cybernetic and consciousnetic organization.

What none of them addresses is the Consciounetic: the bare fact that there is experiencing at all. This is not a failure of these theories but a clarification of their scope. They map the structure of experience—its contents, its dynamics, its neural correlates—but they do not explain why there is a structure to be mapped. As Chalmers has articulated, when we think and perceive, there is information-processing, but there is also a subjective aspect (Chalmers, 1995). The subjective aspect is what the Consciounetic names.

The framework thus provides a principled reason for the persistence of the hard problem. The hard problem is hard not because we lack data or ingenuity, but because it asks about a different level of reality than our standard methods address (Chalmers, 1995; Levine, 1983). Explaining the mechanisms of consciousness is one task; understanding the condition of presence is another. The two tasks are complementary but non-identical.

10.3 Bridging Traditions

Crucially, this reframing bridges rather than polarizes materialist and idealist traditions. For materialist approaches, it motivates a refined empirical agenda aimed at identifying the minimal neural and bodily conditions under which presence persists when regulation is attenuated or suspended (Koch et al., 2016; Travis and Pearson, 2000). Dreaming, sensory deprivation, meditative absorption, and transitions into and out of anesthesia become salient research paradigms—not because they are exotic, but because they isolate presence from the regulatory activity that ordinarily accompanies it (Windt, 2015; Thompson, 2015; Feinstein et al., 2018).

For idealist and panpsychist approaches, it offers a disciplined account of unity without metaphysical inflation, locating fundamentality at the level of presence rather than at the level of subjects or systems (Kastrup, 2019; Goff, 2019). The Consciounetic is not mind in the sense of a thinking subject; it is the prior condition for any subject-object distinction. Wheeler’s participatory universe, in which observers are not external spectators but active participants in bringing reality into being, finds a precise articulation here (Wheeler, 1990; Stapp, 2011).

In both cases, the distinction between presence and regulation prevents category errors that have long obscured the debate. Materialists need not deny the irreducibility of presence; they can investigate its conditions while acknowledging that presence is not one more mechanism. Idealists need not reject the findings of neuroscience; they can interpret them as characterizations of consciounetic organization within a field of presence that neuroscience presupposes but does not explain.

10.4 Practical and Methodological Consequences

Far from being a merely conceptual exercise, this framework yields practical consequences for research in consciousness.

First, it redirects neuroscientific inquiry toward low-action, low-stimulus states (Raichle et al., 2001; Lutz et al., 2008). If presence can be dissociated from access, report, and task engagement, then paradigms that minimize these factors become essential. Resting-state neuroimaging, sleep and dream research, meditation studies, and sensory deprivation protocols are not peripheral curiosities but central methodologies for a science of presence.

Second, it clarifies the scope and limits of computational models (Searle, 1980; Block, 1978). No amount of computational complexity, integration, or self-modeling suffices to produce presence. A perfect functional duplicate may reproduce all cybernetic and

consciousnetic organization while lacking the Consciounetic altogether. This does not mean that artificial systems cannot be conscious, but it means that consciousness cannot be inferred from functional organization alone.

Third, it legitimizes phenomenological and contemplative methodologies as sources of constraint rather than anecdote (Varela, 1996; Petitmengin, 2006). First-person reports, when generated under rigorous conditions, provide data about the structure and invariants of presence that no third-person method can replace. The neurophenomenological research program, which integrates first-person phenomenology with neuroscientific investigation, is not a concession to subjectivism but a methodological necessity (Lutz and Thompson, 2003).

Fourth, it suggests that progress in the science of consciousness may require not ever more elaborate tasks, but carefully designed absences of task. The Consciounetic is not disclosed by doing but by the cessation of doing. Contemplative traditions have long recognized this; their practices can be understood as experimental protocols for attenuating consciousnetic regulation while preserving presence (Dunne, 2011; Forman, 1990).

10.5 Directions for Future Work

The framework opens directions for future work in at least two domains.

In the empirical domain, the challenge is to develop paradigms capable of isolating the neural and physiological correlates of presence as distinct from the correlates of access, report, and regulation. This requires careful operationalization: what would it mean to detect presence in the absence of behavioral markers? The study of patients in minimally conscious states, advanced meditators in objectless awareness, and dreamers in lucid dreams may provide the necessary conditions (Koch et al., 2016; Thompson, 2015; Travis and Pearson, 2000).

In the philosophical domain, the framework invites exploration of what might be called phenomenological signatures of ontological unity. If the Consciounetic is singular, and if consciousnetic agents are expressions of this singularity rather than separate instantiations, then certain phenomena may become intelligible that resist explanation at the level of cybernetic causation. Synchronicities—meaningful correlations lacking apparent causal mediation—are one example (Jung, 1960). Such phenomena need not be understood as violations of physical causality, but as relations intelligible at the level of presence rather than at the level of mechanism. This observation does not constitute empirical proof of the Consciounetic, but it suggests a possible avenue for investigating the phenomenological implications of ontological unity.

10.6 What This Article Does and Does Not Claim

This article does not claim that the Consciounetic is measurable. Presence, by its nature, may not admit of the kind of objectification that measurement requires. What the article claims is that confusing presence with what is measurable has distorted the field of consciousness studies.

The problem of consciousness is often framed as the challenge of explaining how experience emerges from function. The perspective developed here inverts that framing. Presence does not emerge from regulation; regulation unfolds within presence. The qualitative properties of qualia—the felt redness of red, the sting of pain, the texture of

joy—are manifestations of consciousnetic regulation operating through cybernetic substrates (Nagel, 1974; Jackson, 1982). Qualia research maps the topology of experience; it does not explain why there is a topology at all.

There is a subjective aspect to experience that remains inherently private to the observer (Nagel, 1974). The structure of an individual consciousness as a whole—some kind of structured bundle of qualia—could in principle turn out to be identical with a structure of neural activity accessible by future neuroscience, but the qualitative properties of qualia, and the fact that they appear at all, could not be captured by such structural identity alone (Chalmers, 1995). This is not mysterianism; it is a recognition of the difference between structure and presence.

Clarifying this simple asymmetry does not dissolve the mystery of consciousness, but it does ensure that our questions are finally aimed at the right target. The Consciounetic is not a solution to the hard problem; it is a restatement of what the hard problem is actually about. Once we recognize that presence is not a mechanism, we stop looking for the mechanism that produces it. We ask instead: what are the conditions under which presence appears, and how can we investigate them without reducing presence to something it is not?

10.7 Closing Remarks

The triadic framework of cybernetics, consciousnetics, and the Consciounetic offers a conceptual scaffold for the science and philosophy of consciousness. It does not resolve all debates, but it clarifies what is at stake in each. It does not provide a theory of consciousness, but it specifies the levels at which different theories operate.

Cybernetics describes the instrumental regulation of systems through feedback, control, and information flow. It is powerful, productive, and indifferent to presence.

Consciousnetics describes the self-regulatory activity of agents operating within presence. It captures the lived, normative, first-personal dimension of experience—the fact that experience matters to the one who has it.

The Consciounetic denotes presence itself: singular, non-agentive, non-regulatory. It is the condition for the appearance of anything whatsoever.

These three levels are not competing theories but complementary descriptions of distinct aspects of reality. Confusing them generates the characteristic impasses of consciousness studies. Distinguishing them allows us to see that neuroscience, phenomenology, and contemplative inquiry are not rivals but partners in a shared investigation.

The study of consciousness stands at a crossroads. One path continues the action-based, task-driven paradigms that have yielded so much knowledge of cybernetic and consciousnetic organization. The other path turns toward presence itself, asking not what consciousness does but that it is.

This article has argued that both paths are necessary, but only if we are clear about where each leads. The first path maps the structure of experience; the second seeks the ground upon which that structure appears. Together, they may bring us closer to understanding the deepest fact of all: that there is something it is like to be.

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